

# Der Blaue Reiter

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In 1911 in Munich, another group of artists formed Der Blaue Reiter ('The Blue Rider'). They included Wassily Kandinsky, Franz Marc (1880–1916), Paul Klee, Alexej von Jawlensky (1864–1941) and Auguste Macke (1887–1914). The name derived from a Kandinsky painting of 1903, used on the cover of their 1912 almanac, which contained essays on art by both Kandinsky and Marc. Both artists admired the power and beauty of horses, and both believed in the mystical significance of the colour blue. Drawing inspiration from Van Gogh, Gauguin, Munch and Primitivism, they believed they could express spiritual values through colour and abstraction.

Kandinsky led the group, and said that simple shapes and bold colours can portray moods and feelings, eliminating the need for subject matter. All the artists painted simplified, lively, colourful images, conveying their feelings about the world. But when the First World War broke out, Marc and Macke were drafted into military service and killed, while Kandinsky, von Jawlensky and other Russian artists who had joined them, had to return home.



Kandinsky, *Untitled Improvisation III*, 1914